that, but he kept wondering if he was doing the right thing by travelling so much on work and ignoring his family.

I listened without uttering a word. This man had been a tireless traveller. Much like his dreams, his body was often in the sky, I thought, as Sarabhai would be flying almost every day from city to city, inspiring young scientists to do India proud and striking bargains with space-faring countries to help India achieve its aspiration beyond the stratosphere. While in India, he would fly from Ahmedabad to Trivandrum to chair a meeting with us for three hours and rush to the airport to catch a flight to Chennai for a family reunion and be back the next morning to continue the meeting in Trivandrum.

In passion, Sarabhai overtook Homi Bhabha who had handpicked Sarabhai as his successor at the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE), and later for the space mission. Sarabhai simultaneously held the post of the DAE chairman and headed the space programme. From the first job he drew a salary, from the second he took a nominal one rupee before it became fashionable for many politicians to take a token remuneration. And most of his flying was on his own expense. Sarabhai, hailing from an aristocratic family in Gujarat, could afford it handsomely.

At work, Sarabhai exhibited dual nature. At DAE, he was less accessible and sometimes a terror. At the space centres he would throw a hand around anyone and chit-chat. Homi Bhabha was known to be a proud boss who took his dignity too seriously. When Bhabha entered a lift, nobody else would get in. Sarabhai, on the other hand, would squeeze himself to a corner of an Ambassador car after getting five people into the vehicle. When Sarabhai landed at any airport in India, there would be a fleet of family cars awaiting him; but he would hop into a car in which he could discuss rocketry with a colleague on way to one of his umpteen work places.

Sometime during the flight to New York, Sarabhai told me, ‘If you come into such a job, then you don’t deserve to have a family.’ The sight of my wife with our toddler son waving at me at the Trivandrum airport flashed through my mind. I tried to sleep.